

Bookkeeping as Protocol Byproduct: Self-Closing Ledger Periods in the FIGARO Settlement Primitive

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Abstract

Modern accounting rests on a specific historical innovation: double-entry bookkeeping, formalized in Pacioli [1494] and elaborated over five centuries into the apparatus of the modern firm. Pacioli's innovation solved a specific problem — how to track the position of an opaque economic entity over time, in a form that could be reconciled, audited, taxed, and adjudicated. The solution made the modern firm possible [Sombart, 1916, Chandler, 1977] and generated the professions that sit on top of it: bookkeeping, accounting, auditing, tax preparation, and the commercial law that treats books as the authoritative record of the firm's economic acts.

This paper argues that the FIGARO settlement primitive formalized in the mechanism paper and implemented in the implementation paper makes that apparatus optional for a class of economic activity. A FIGARO process — a root bonded commitment together with its sub-orders, terms of agreement, and lifecycle attestations — is a *self-closing ledger period* in the precise accounting sense. Every entry is on chain, content-addressed, and signed; the conservation law proven in the mechanism paper is the bookkeeping identity; resolution is the closing entries; process dissolution is the period close. The contract holds a complete balance-sheet position during the life of the process; the events constitute a complete journal; the emitted lifecycle data constitutes contemporaneous supporting documentation.

The consequence is not that accounting as a discipline disappears. The consequence is that a specific class of professional work — record-keeping, reconciliation, period-end closing, basic audit of the records themselves — becomes protocol byproduct rather than professional service. What remains genuinely professional is interpretive: going-concern judgment, revenue-recognition timing under ambiguity, fair-value assessment, regulatory translation, and the forms of audit that test the relation between records and real-world performance rather than the internal consistency of records. We argue the shift is structurally analogous to the 1494 innovation that created the apparatus in the first place: a new technology at the records layer that makes a specific class of prior work unnecessary and leaves another class untouched.

Keywords: bookkeeping, accounting, auditing, double-entry, triple-entry, smart contracts, verifiable records, Pacioli

1 Introduction

Every modern firm maintains books of account. The books record what the firm owns (assets), what it owes (liabilities), what has flowed in and out (revenues and expenses), and how these quantities have changed over a defined period. The books make the firm legible to itself, to its investors, to its regulators, and to its counterparties. The books are the foundation of the

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firm’s legal personality in a precise sense: the existence of books is what distinguishes a firm as a trackable economic entity from a loose arrangement of exchange.

The books are not an incidental feature. They are the infrastructure on which much of modern commercial law rests. Tax law assumes books and operates against them. Securities law requires disclosure of books. Insolvency proceedings run against books. Due diligence in mergers and acquisitions is substantially an examination of books. Auditing is the profession that verifies books, and the auditor’s report is a legal artifact with specific consequences. The apparatus is substantial, costly, and well-adapted to the problem it solves.

What problem does it solve? Pacioli [1494] identified the underlying difficulty: an economic entity with continuous operations needs a way to answer the question *what is its position?* at any moment. Cash positions alone are insufficient because obligations outstanding are not captured; asset lists alone are insufficient because liabilities and equity are not distinguished; transaction logs alone are insufficient because the cumulative position is not summarized. Pacioli’s double-entry bookkeeping solved this by recording every transaction as a balanced pair of debits and credits, allowing the cumulative position to be derived at any time as a trial balance, and reconciled to zero if no errors had been made. Every subsequent layer of the apparatus — accounting, auditing, commercial law, tax law — was built on the assumption that Pacioli’s books exist and are more or less reliable.

This paper asks what happens to that apparatus when the books are not maintained by any party but are instead constituted by a settlement protocol as the byproduct of its operation. The answer we develop: a specific class of accounting work becomes unnecessary, a distinct class remains valuable, and a third class — commercial law and audit practices that assume the firm is opaque and its books need external verification — becomes structurally inapplicable to the class of economic activity that settles through the protocol.

What this paper is not. We do not argue that all economic activity migrates to Figaro processes. We do not argue that accounting as a discipline ends. We do not advocate for any specific regulatory response. We claim only that a particular historical apparatus, designed for a particular problem, has a narrower scope of applicability once that problem can be solved at the settlement layer. What to do with the narrowed scope is a matter for accounting research, regulatory policy, and the profession itself.

Paper organization. Section 2 describes the Pacioli stack — double-entry, the apparatus on top, and the costs and benefits of the arrangement. Section 4 treats the prior literature on triple-entry bookkeeping and blockchain-accounting, acknowledging the antecedents we extend. Section 5 develops the central technical claim: a Figaro process is a self-closing ledger period. Section 6 describes what stops being necessary. Section 7 describes what continues and why. Section 8 connects to the institutional-economics companion paper. Section 9 connects to the law-and-evidence companion paper. Section 10 states what the paper does not claim. Section 11 concludes.

2 The Pacioli Stack

Pacioli [1494] published *Summa de arithmetica, geometria, proportioni et proportionalita* in Venice in 1494. The treatise was a general mathematics reference, but its thirty-six-chapter section *De computis et scripturis* contained the first printed exposition of double-entry bookkeeping as practiced by Venetian merchants. The system was not invented by Pacioli — it had been in use in Italian commercial cities for at least a century — but his codification became the reference text and carried the method into every subsequent tradition of commercial accounting.

The method is simple. Every transaction is recorded twice, once as a debit to one account and once as a credit to another. The sum of all debits always equals the sum of all credits. At

any moment the trial balance — the list of all account balances — sums to zero if no errors have been made. The books are therefore self-checking: an error produces an imbalance that can be located and corrected. The cumulative position of the entity is derivable at any time by summarizing account balances into a balance sheet (assets, liabilities, equity) and an income statement (revenues, expenses, net income).

Why the innovation was decisive. Sombart [1916] argued — in a claim that has been debated but not decisively refuted — that double-entry bookkeeping was a necessary condition for the rise of modern capitalism. The argument is that without a reliable method for tracking cumulative position, an economic entity cannot grow beyond the scale at which its position is visible to a single person from direct observation. A cook running a kitchen can track inventories and obligations in their head; a merchant house running dozens of ships cannot. Double-entry made scale possible by making position legible under distributed operations. Subsequent historians (Chandler 1977 on the managerial firm; Yamey 2005 on the empirical spread of the method) have refined the argument but not the structural point.

The apparatus on top. Over five centuries a substantial professional apparatus has grown on top of the books. Bookkeepers maintain journals and post to ledgers. Accountants produce periodic financial statements, make closing entries, compute taxes, and advise on treatment of ambiguous transactions. External auditors verify that the statements fairly represent the firm’s position. Regulators require filings based on the books. Tax authorities compute liabilities against the books. Commercial lawyers litigate disputes whose subject matter is what the books say or should have said. Power [1997] describes the resulting *audit society* — a social formation in which verification by credentialed third parties is the default response to questions of organizational reliability.

The apparatus is real, well-established, and substantially functional. It is also costly. Compliance-related accounting costs for public companies in mature jurisdictions run into percentages of revenue; small firms spend a meaningful fraction of their overhead on tax and financial-statement preparation; audit budgets are substantial; forensic-accounting specialists are expensive. The apparatus is justified, under the existing model, because it answers a question that cannot be answered otherwise — is the firm’s position as its managers say it is? — and because the alternative (believe the firm’s own claim) has been tried historically and repeatedly failed.

3 Banking as Coordinating Infrastructure Since the Renaissance

The Pacioli innovation of Section 2 did not arise in isolation. It codified a bookkeeping practice that was itself one layer of a broader coordination infrastructure assembled by Italian merchant cities to solve the problem of trust at distance. The arc from that infrastructure to contemporary global finance is long, well-studied, and not the subject of this paper; we summarize just enough of it to locate the self-closing ledger period of Section 5 within it.

The Medici configuration. By the middle of the fifteenth century the Medici bank had assembled a coordination infrastructure whose components — bills of exchange, correspondent networks across foreign branches, partnership structures separating ownership from operation — together addressed the central problem of pre-modern long-distance commerce: how one merchant could extend credit, or make payment, to another across a frontier without either of them being present to enforce the agreement in person [de Roover, 1963]. The bill of exchange was the load-bearing instrument. A merchant in Florence could draw a bill against a Medici branch in Bruges, which would honor it on presentation by the payee; the trust required was trust in the Medici bank, not trust between the merchants. Pacioli’s 1494 codification sat atop

this arrangement. Double-entry made the position of a multi-branch bank legible; the bank in turn made the position of its merchant clients settleable.

From Amsterdam to SWIFT. The institutional successors of the Medici configuration are familiar. The Amsterdam Wisselbank (1609) generalized bill-of-exchange settlement into a standing municipal institution; the Bank of England (1694) generalized it further into a national reserve; the nineteenth-century emergence of central banking and the twentieth-century Bretton Woods / SWIFT / CLS configuration extended the same idea — coordinated settlement through trusted intermediaries — to the global scale at which it now operates. Braudel [1982] is the standard Braudel-scale treatment; Kindleberger [1993] the standard treatment of the successive generalizations. The configuration has evolved through several distinct monetary substrates (specie-backed, gold-standard, Bretton-Woods-dollar, fiat-floating) but has not changed in its basic structure: trust in a counterparty is underwritten by trust in an intermediary that keeps authoritative books about the position between them.

The self-closing period as structural inflection. Against that long arc, the mechanism of Section 5 — in which the books are kept by the protocol rather than by an intermediary — registers as a structural inflection rather than an incremental innovation. Pacioli made the books legible; the Medici configuration made them enforceable across distance by having a trusted institution keep them. FIGARO makes them enforceable across distance *without* a trusted institution, by locating the keeping of the books at the protocol layer. This is not a claim that FIGARO displaces banking infrastructure; it is a claim about where the present primitive sits in the longer structural arc. The bank-shaped intermediary was a response to the enforcement-at-distance problem that has defined the coordination infrastructure of commerce since the Renaissance. A settlement primitive that enforces bilateral agreements directly, without a bank-shaped intermediary, does not extend Pacioli’s apparatus; it refactors the enforcement-at-distance problem that Pacioli’s apparatus was one layer of.

The remainder of this paper is concerned with the accounting and audit consequences of the refactor. We note the banking-structural observation here because Section 5 is otherwise susceptible to being read as a narrow technical proposal about bookkeeping, when its consequence is a rearrangement of a five-hundred-year-old institutional stack.

4 Triple-Entry and Its Limits

The idea that Pacioli’s double-entry might be extended to solve additional problems has a small but identifiable literature. Ijiri [1986] proposed triple-entry bookkeeping in which transactions create not two entries but three: one for each party and a third for a “commitment” or “force” record that captures the economic momentum of the activity. Ijiri’s motivation was accounting-theoretic — he argued that conventional double-entry under-records the forces that drive economic change — but the structural move (three records per transaction rather than two) anticipated later cryptographic proposals.

Grigg [2005] revived the idea in a blockchain-adjacent register. Grigg’s triple-entry proposes that two parties to a transaction each keep a record in the conventional way, and a third party — a cryptographically signed receipt that both parties can reference — serves as the attesting third record. In practice the third record played the role now played by blockchain transaction records: a tamper-evident, timestamped, publicly verifiable artifact that neither party could modify after the fact. Grigg’s contribution was to formalize what the Ricardian contracts community had been practicing: that cryptographic receipts could carry the legal weight of a signed document while also functioning as an accounting record.

A larger recent literature has explored the broader claim that blockchain technology changes the accounting problem. Dai and Vasarhelyi [2017] propose that blockchain-based transaction

records can form the basis for real-time audit, replacing periodic audit cycles. Yermack [2017] surveys corporate-governance applications of blockchain, including the implications for the audit function. Various industry and professional-society reports have explored blockchain and accounting in the period 2017–2022.

Where the prior literature stops. The recurring limit of the prior work is that it treats the chain as a *third, attesting* record alongside the two parties’ own records. The parties still maintain books; the chain provides cryptographic reinforcement. This is a real improvement over pure party-held records (reconciliation becomes faster; attestation becomes cryptographic; the third record cannot be unilaterally altered), but the structure of the apparatus remains unchanged: the parties keep books, the chain attests, the audit function verifies that the parties’ books match the chain and match each other.

The Figaro extension is different. In a Figaro process, the parties do not need to maintain books at all — not because they can choose not to, but because the protocol-level records are themselves the complete accounting record of the process. The chain is not an attesting third; it is the primary and only record required. We develop this claim in the next section.

5 A Figaro Process as a Self-Closing Ledger Period

We now develop the central technical claim. Let a *process* be the object defined in the mechanism paper: a root bonded commitment, zero or more sub-order commitments sharing a common root buyer and currency, a monotonic cumulative-value accumulator, and a buyer-initiated atomic resolution. Every commit is a pair of dual-signed EIP-712 payloads; every resolution is an atomic distribution governed by the payout functions $\pi_{s,i} = 2G_i + P_i$ and $\pi_{b,i} = P_i$, where P_i is the payment for order i and G_i is the cumulative value accumulator snapshot at order i . The conservation law (Remark 3.5 of the mechanism paper) states that $\pi_{s,i} + \pi_{b,i} = C_{s,i} + C_{b,i}$ for every order: the total distributed equals the total locked.

We claim this structure is equivalent to a self-closing ledger period in the accounting sense. We proceed in three steps.

5.1 The contract state as a balance-sheet position

At any time t during the life of a process, the contract holds an escrow balance equal to the sum of all active bonds: $2G_N$ in seller bonds (cumulative over all committed orders) plus $\sum_i 2P_i$ in buyer bonds (one per committed order). This balance is a liability of the contract toward the parties: each buyer’s bond is a liability toward that buyer; each seller’s bond is a liability toward that seller; together with the obligation to pay the seller’s payment at resolution, the contract’s liabilities at any time during process life sum to exactly the assets it holds.

Definition 5.1 (Custodial Ledger Identity). At any reachable state of the contract, for a given process Π , the escrowed custody balance attributable to Π equals the aggregated claim of the process’s counterparties against the contract:

$$\text{custody}(\Pi, t) = \sum_{i \in \text{active}(\Pi)} (C_{s,i} + C_{b,i}) = \sum_{i \in \text{active}(\Pi)} (\pi_{s,i}^{\text{committed}} + \pi_{b,i}^{\text{committed}}). \quad (1)$$

This is the bookkeeping identity in escrow-accounting form. Assets held equal liabilities owed. The contract is not an economic entity in its own right; it is a custodian whose position reconciles to zero net at all times.

5.2 Commits as journal entries; resolution as closing entries

Each `commit` call produces a journal entry of the form:

- Debit: *Custody — buyer B bond* $+2P_i$
- Debit: *Custody — seller S_i bond* $+2G_i$
- Credit: *Liability to B (refund obligation)* $+2P_i$
- Credit: *Liability to S_i (payout obligation)* $+2G_i$

The journal entry balances by construction (debits = credits) and is recorded as an `OrderCommitted` event (with companion events `OrderSeller`, `OrderCurrency` for index completeness) with a cryptographic signature from each party and a block timestamp.

The `resolveProcess` call produces, for each active order, a closing entry:

- Debit: *Liability to S_i* $+(2G_i + P_i)$
- Debit: *Liability to B* $+P_i$
- Credit: *Custody — seller S_i bond* $2G_i$
- Credit: *Custody — buyer B bond* $2P_i$
- (Net movement: the payment P_i transfers from buyer to seller.)

The closing entries zero out all custodial accounts and liability accounts for the process. The contract returns to zero position with respect to this process, and the process itself is marked resolved.

5.3 Supporting documentation and the complete record

The accounting record of a process consists of:

- *Journal entries*: `OrderCommitted`, `OrderResolved`, `ProcessResolved` events. Timestamped, signed, content-addressed, publicly verifiable.
- *Supporting documentation*: the `agreementHash` field of each commitment, which binds both parties to a specific off-chain document (contract text, specification, order details). The document's content can be anything the parties choose; the hash proves which document is at issue.
- *Contemporaneous lifecycle evidence*: the schema-typed attestations emitted via `AttestationCoordinator` during process life — proximity proofs, handoff attestations, quality disclosures, lifecycle-stage transitions. These are the analogue of working papers and supporting receipts in conventional accounting, with the important distinction that their class (settlement byproduct vs. discretionary attestation) matters for evidentiary weight (evidence-and-law paper).

Together, these constitute a complete and contemporaneously produced accounting record for the process, from opening through resolution. No party maintains additional books; the record is complete without them.

5.4 Reconstruction

The companion implementation paper documents the SDK primitive `reconstruct()` which replays events into a state machine that exactly reproduces the kernel state. This primitive is equivalent to a universal trial-balance generator: any reader with read access to the chain can reconstruct the complete ledger state of any process, at any historical moment, without any party's cooperation. The reconstruction is deterministic, verifiable against the chain, and does not depend on any off-chain record beyond the `agreementHash` references.

The period-end property. When a process resolves, its ledger period closes. All custodial balances for the process return to zero; all liabilities are discharged; all payments have flowed to their recipients. The process-specific ledger ceases to have active entries. Records remain on chain indefinitely — the audit trail does not disappear — but no further transactions occur against the closed ledger. This is the period-end property of conventional accounting: the books for the period are finalized and archived; the next period’s books open anew.

6 What Stops Being Necessary

We enumerate the classes of professional work that become unnecessary for economic activity that settles through Figaro processes. “Unnecessary” means: the work performs a function that the protocol performs equivalently or better at zero marginal cost. It does not mean: the work is valueless, nor that practitioners lose their livelihoods overnight.

Bookkeeping as record-keeping. The classical bookkeeping function — maintaining journals, posting to ledgers, reconciling sub-ledgers to the general ledger, periodic trial-balance runs — is protocol byproduct for activity that settles through Figaro processes. No party needs to maintain this record because the protocol maintains it, and any reader can reconstruct it. The labor historically performed by bookkeepers in recording transactions into account structures is done by the event log, the content-addressing, and the reconstruction primitive.

Period-end close. The conventional period-end procedure — posting adjusting entries, preparing trial balance, reconciling bank statements, accruing revenues and expenses, running the closing entries — is performed automatically when a process resolves. The protocol has no accrual ambiguity (every commitment has definite amount and timing), no reconciliation step (there is nothing to reconcile against), and no closing adjustments beyond the resolution itself.

Internal audit of the records. The internal-audit function that verifies the firm’s own books against supporting documentation and transaction records is subsumed: the records and the documentation are on the same chain, linked by content hashes, with cryptographic authentication of signatures and block timestamps. There is nothing to verify because there is no second record to reconcile against.

External audit of records-to-records correspondence. The external-audit function — verifying that the firm’s reported position reconciles to its underlying records — is also subsumed. There is no “reported position” separate from the chain; the chain *is* the position. An audit function that attested to this correspondence would be attesting to an identity.

Disputes over what the books say. Commercial-law disputes whose subject matter is what the books say or should have said — was this expense recorded, was that liability disclosed, did revenue recognition occur at the right moment by the firm’s own criteria — become moot for Figaro-process activity. The chain is the record; disagreements about its content are about interpretation, not about existence.

7 What Continues

The professional work that continues is the work that was never really about bookkeeping. Three categories in particular.

Judgment about what records mean. Revenue recognition under ambiguity (has the performance obligation been satisfied?), going-concern assessment (is the entity a going concern?), fair-value assessment (what is this asset or liability worth?), impairment judgments, and the full range of *interpretive* accounting work remain genuinely human. The protocol records what happened; it does not determine how what happened should be interpreted under a particular accounting framework (GAAP, IFRS, tax code, or sector-specific regulation). A wallet cohort that has received N FIG tokens via staged merkle airdrop has a record that this happened; whether those tokens constitute revenue, a capital contribution, an airdrop deemed non-recognition-triggering, or something else depends on interpretive work that requires human judgment.

Translation for non-technical readers. Narrative management discussion and analysis (MD&A), executive summaries of financial position for boards and external stakeholders, regulatory filings in jurisdictional formats, and the preparation of non-technical explanations of technical financial positions remain professional work. The chain is complete but unreadable to most intended audiences; the accountant or auditor becomes, in this residual function, a translator rather than a record-keeper.

Audit of the relation between records and reality. The most substantive remaining audit function is verifying that on-chain records correspond to real-world performance. Did the cook actually prepare the food? Did the courier actually deliver it? Did the attested GHG disclosure actually reflect the measured quantity? These questions ask whether the on-chain record is a faithful representation of off-chain reality. The protocol cannot answer them; it can only record what was signed. An auditor attesting that on-chain records correspond to measured off-chain performance is doing genuinely new work, and may become the core function of the post-Pacioli audit profession. This is not the work of reconciling records to other records; it is the work of reconciling records to the world.

Regulatory compliance ahead of regulatory catch-up. Tax law, securities law, and sector-specific regulation assume conventional books. For an extended period — probably decades — firms operating on Figaro processes will need to produce conventional financial statements from their on-chain records to satisfy regulatory requirements. This translation work is a professional function. Eventually regulation may update to reference chain state directly; in the interim, the accountant’s role includes producing traditional outputs from non-traditional inputs.

8 Connection to the Institutional-Economics Argument

The companion institutional-economics paper argues that the firm’s coordination function dissolves in a precise region, and that the firm becomes one organizational pattern among several in that region. The present paper identifies an additional function of the firm that dissolves alongside the coordination function: the firm’s *self-knowledge* function.

A firm is not only a coordination mechanism; it is also an entity that knows what it is through its books. The subordination overlay (§3.1 of the institutional-economics paper) is partially a solution to a coordination problem and partially a solution to a records problem: a firm that cannot maintain accurate books cannot grow, cannot attract investment, cannot pay taxes, cannot contract with third parties who require disclosure, cannot satisfy regulators. Bookkeeping is one of the functions that made the firm boundary necessary, not just because coordination was expensive but because self-knowledge at scale required the records apparatus.

When the records apparatus becomes protocol byproduct, the firm boundary is less necessary for self-knowledge reasons as well. A wallet cohort that participates in many process trees has its aggregate position fully visible without any consolidation. A treasury that receives payments

and disburses grants has its complete ledger readable from chain state. The firm is still one possible way to bundle the non-coordination, non-self-knowledge functions that remain (capital aggregation, organizational knowledge, risk pooling, legal personhood), but the motivation to bundle is weaker than it was in the pre-protocol environment.

This tightens the institutional argument without changing its substance: the firm’s demotion from privileged organizational container to one pattern among several (institutional-economics paper; Section 5 above) rests on both the coordination argument developed there and the self-knowledge argument developed here.

9 Connection to the Legal-Evidence Argument

The companion evidence-and-law paper argues that the on-chain record provides evidence that off-chain adjudicative forums already know how to use. The present paper extends this: the on-chain record is not only evidentiary; it is *constitutive* of the accounting record.

The distinction matters for two reasons.

Admissibility vs. primacy. The evidence-and-law paper establishes that on-chain records are admissible as evidence under eIDAS, UCC, UNCITRAL, and similar frameworks. The admissibility question asks whether the record can be introduced in a proceeding and weighed. The primacy question asks whether the record is *the* account of the economic activity or merely *an* account of it. For Figaro processes, the on-chain record is the primary account; no other account exists unless a party chooses to maintain one separately. In a dispute about what the accounting record of a process says, the chain is not corroborating evidence for party-held books; the chain *is* the books, and any party-held document is a summary or translation.

Class A and Class B records, revisited. The evidence-and-law paper distinguishes Class A records (settlement byproduct, produced mechanically by the bonding game) from Class B records (discretionary attestations, produced voluntarily by self-interested parties). The accounting framing of the present paper clarifies the distinction: Class A records are the primary ledger entries (journal and closing entries); Class B records are supporting documentation (working papers, evidentiary exhibits, operational attestations). Both are part of the complete accounting record, but they carry different evidentiary weight and support different classes of downstream use. An audit that tests the records against real-world performance (Section 7 above) is primarily an audit of Class B reliability, since Class A is self-verifying by construction.

10 Scope and Limitations

The paper’s argument is bounded in several ways that we state explicitly to preempt predictable misreadings.

The argument does not generalize to all economic activity. We claim only that the accounting apparatus becomes protocol byproduct *for the class of economic activity that settles through Figaro processes*. Most contemporary economic activity does not settle through Figaro processes and will not in the foreseeable future; for that activity, the Pacioli stack remains necessary.

The argument does not claim accounting is obsolete. Professional accounting work continues in the three categories identified in Section 7: interpretive work, translation, and audit against reality. The argument reduces the scope of record-keeping work, not of accounting work in general.

The argument does not claim regulatory simplification. Regulators have their own institutional logic and will adapt to the protocol at their own pace. Tax authorities in particular are unlikely to accept chain-state inspection as a substitute for conventional filings in the short term. The professional work of translating on-chain records into jurisdictional-format filings will continue indefinitely and may even expand.

The argument does not claim the chain is infallible. The on-chain record is only as reliable as the chain’s consensus and the cryptographic primitives underneath. A chain reorganization that unwinds finalized state, a signature-scheme break, or a validator-level censorship event could all compromise the accounting record. These risks exist and are not new. What is new is that they are concentrated at the chain layer rather than distributed across party-held books; whether that is a net improvement depends on the relative reliability of the two regimes.

The argument does not claim accounting fraud is impossible. Fraud in the Figaro-process regime takes different forms than in the conventional regime: not the misstatement of internal books (which are unforgeable), but the misrepresentation of off-chain facts that the on-chain record hashes against (forged agreement documents, falsified attestations, collusive parties). The FIG token paper and the evidence-and-law paper both discuss adjacent fraud surfaces. The Pacioli apparatus did not eliminate accounting fraud; it reshaped it. So does the protocol.

11 Conclusion

Pacioli [1494] solved a specific problem: how to make the position of an opaque economic entity legible over time. The solution was double-entry bookkeeping, and the apparatus built on top of it — bookkeepers, accountants, auditors, commercial lawyers, tax preparers — is one of the defining professional formations of the modern economy. The apparatus solves the problem it was designed for.

The FIGARO settlement primitive solves a different version of the same problem at a different layer: it makes the position of a process-scoped economic event transparent at the protocol layer, as the byproduct of ordinary operation. The parties do not need to maintain books because the protocol constitutes the books. Custody is balanced at every reachable state by the conservation law; journal entries are events; closing entries are resolution; the period closes when the process dissolves; the records persist on chain indefinitely. The reconstruction primitive makes the complete record accessible to any reader without cooperation from the parties.

The consequence is that a specific class of accounting work — record-keeping, reconciliation, period-end closing, audit of the records themselves — becomes protocol byproduct rather than professional service. What remains professional is genuinely interpretive and human: judgment about what records mean, translation for non-technical audiences, and the audit function that tests the relation between records and real-world performance.

The third inflection. Pacioli made entity-tracking possible (1494). Nakamoto [2008] and Buterin [2014] made settlement distributed (2008–2015). The FIGARO primitive makes records process-scoped and self-closing (2026). Each inflection reduces a specific apparatus from necessary to optional for the class of activity it covers, leaving the rest intact. The accounting profession is at the beginning of absorbing the third inflection. The present paper is an attempt to describe what it entails before the debate becomes muddled by the usual overpromising of blockchain-accounting claims and the usual under-appreciation of what specifically has changed.

A note on what is gained. We have written mostly about what is no longer necessary. It is worth stating what is gained. The accounting apparatus described in Section 2 costs substantial fractions of firm overhead and imposes substantial compliance costs on participants. The apparatus is also a gating function: small firms and individual participants who cannot afford professional accounting are partially excluded from certain forms of economic activity (formal contracts, audited transactions, disclosures that require an attestor). A protocol that produces the accounting record as a byproduct of ordinary settlement makes the record available to participants who could not otherwise have afforded it. This is a distributional effect: accounting infrastructure becomes available at the protocol layer to participants who previously faced the full cost of the apparatus. The consequences — for smaller economic units, for participants in jurisdictions without strong accounting-profession infrastructure, for machine and agent-led economic activity whose scale does not justify an accountant — are worth working out in their own right, and we expect subsequent work in the portfolio or by others to address them.

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I owe this paper’s starting observation to an exchange with a collaborator who framed the core contract, informally, as “a balance sheet whose process is a P&L.” The framing captured in plain language what would take a specialist considerable technical vocabulary to articulate, and the paper is substantially an elaboration of that framing into the traditions of accounting research it engages. Pacioli deserves most of the remaining credit; for the errors, I alone.

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